organism is a unit of natural selection, it is in the quite different sense of gene ‘vehicle’. The measure of its success is the frequency of its genes in future generations, and the quantity it strives to maximize is what Hamilton defined as ‘inclusive fitness’.

A gene achieves its numerical success in the population by virtue of its (phenotypic) effects on individual bodies. A successful gene is represented in many bodies over a long period of time. It helps those bodies to survive long enough to reproduce in the environment. But the environment means not just the external environment of the body—trees, water, predators, etc.—but also the internal environment, and especially the other genes with which the selfish gene shares a succession of bodies through the population and down the generations. It follows that natural selection favours genes that flourish in the company of other genes in the breeding population. Genes are indeed ‘selfish’ in the sense promoted in this book. They are also *cooperative* with other genes with which they share, not just the present particular body, but bodies in general, generated by the species’ gene pool. A sexually reproducing population is a cartel of mutually compatible, cooperating genes: cooperating today because they have flourished by cooperating through many generations of similar bodies in the ancestral past. The important point to understand (it is much misunderstood) is that the cooperativeness is favoured, not because a group of genes is naturally selected as a whole, but because individual genes are separately selected against the background of the other genes likely to be met in a body, and this means the other genes in the species’ gene pool. The pool, that is, from which every individual of a sexually reproducing species draws its genes as a sample. The genes of the species (but not other species) are continually meeting each other—and cooperating with each other—in a succession of bodies.

We still don’t really understand what drove the origin of sexual reproduction. But a consequence of sexual reproduction was the invention of *the species* as the habitat of cooperating cartels of mutually compatible genes. As explained in the chapter called ‘The long reach of the gene’, the key to the cooperation is that, in every generation, all the genes in a body share the same ‘bottlenecked’ exit route to the future: the sperms or eggs in which they aspire to sail into the next generation. *The Cooperative Gene* would have been an equally appropriate title for this book, and the book itself would not have changed at all. I suspect that a whole lot of mistaken criticisms could have been avoided.